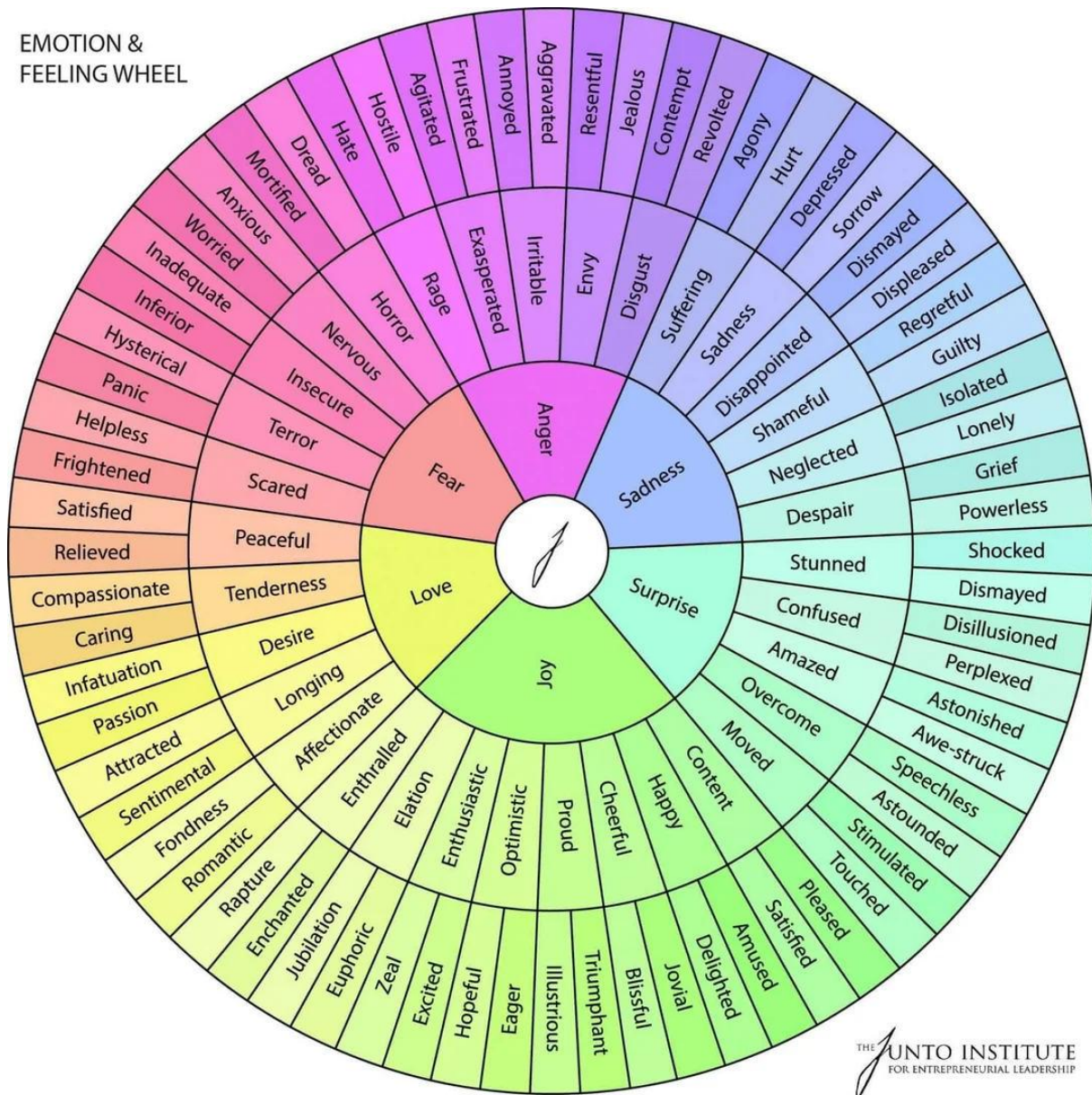


Emotion Wheel

When you think about everything you're trying to achieve in your fantasy story, ultimately it's all about evoking a **deep emotional response** from your readers.

But trying to actually write emotional scenes can be a tricky task.

That's why I was pleasantly surprised when I recently found Robert Plutchik's **Emotion Wheel**:



When I saw this, I knew I had to share it with you.

Why?

Because it contains an insanely powerful principle that all writers should know:

- **Broad**, vague emotions (like anger or sadness) can sometimes fail to move us.
- But **specific**, granular emotions (like sentimentality or panic) feel so much more compelling.

Let me explain...

How to use the Emotion Wheel

If you look at the wheel, you'll see it starts with six basic emotions in the centre:

1. Anger
2. Sadness
3. Surprise
4. Joy
5. Love
6. Fear

Then, as you move outward, those broad emotions start to fragment.

Sadness, for example, splits into:

1. Suffering
2. Sadness
3. Disappointment
4. Shame
5. Neglect
6. Despair

(Yes, I know - it's a bit annoying how some of the emotions on the wheel are adjectives, and some of them are nouns...but that's beside the point.)

And then the outermost ring takes it one step further.

- Shame becomes **guilt** or **remorse**
- Disappointment becomes **powerlessness** or **isolation**

Now we're dealing with very specific emotional flavours.

You can probably start to see how much more interesting a scene gets when your character is acting from *guilt*, rather than just some vague sadness.

Or maybe their sadness manifests as guilt, but as the scene progresses, it shifts to regret, then to depression.

Drilling down into the specific gives you more nuance to play with.

So next time you're thinking about your character's emotions, don't just paint with the broad strokes of those top-level emotions. See if you can go deeper and find the specific flavour of emotion they're having.